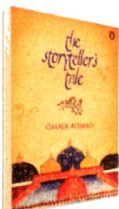


The Story SO FAR

Delhi of another era comes alive in this little book with a civilisational message



THE STORYTELLER'S TALE

by OMIR AHMAD
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By Gillian Wright

In this slim, attractively produced volume, Omair Ahmad constructs tales within tales, drawing on a centuries-old tradition of storytelling. In these tales are echoes of the love found in classical Urdu literature and the courtly love of medieval Europe. Courtly love tended to strike at first sight. It was generally illicit—that is for another man's wife—and frequently unconsummated. Communication presented problems, and so lovers had to send messages to one another through indirect means. In Ahmad's book they do so through narrating stories. These stories are like many we have read in childhood; they have princes and woodcutters, rich and poor and wolves befriending humans. The characters in them, however, show much more introspection than in traditional folk tales and Ahmad uses them to highlight aspects of human nature.

The storyteller of the title is a proud figure who can relate scenes of battle and bloodshed

and finds no difficulty in shocking his listeners, but whose own sentiments are that of a refined and non-violent gentleman. He is in fact a teller of tales fleeing from 18th century Delhi after its destruction at the hands of Afghan armies. Despite having seen the despoilation of his house and city, the storyteller (who is never given a name) holds on to his pride in his art and to his belief in the superiority of the civilisation the city represented. He chose to be a storyteller, he says, to make others understand and recognise beauty, an essential part of that civilisation.

In many ways, he is reminiscent of the 18th century poet Mir Taqi Mir, who wrote nostalgically of Delhi's lost glory:

*Dilli ke na the kuche, aaraq-e-musavvir the,
Jo shakl nazar aayi, tasvir nazar aayi*

(The lanes of Delhi were not mere lanes but pages from a painter's album/Every figure seen there was as perfect as a picture.)

Like thousands of others, Mir found it impossible to continue living in the ruins of his beloved city. He migrated to Lucknow and the court of the Nawab of Avadh, as does the storyteller in this book. On the way, the storyteller comes across a *haveli* belonging to one of the plunderers of Delhi and therefore, one of his enemies. And yet it is in this *haveli* that he is invited to tell his tales, and finds to his surprise, that there is someone who can better him.

The 18th century was an age of poetry, rather than prose. And the *dastaan*, or stories that were recited then were full of ornate poetic imagery and linguistic pyrotechnics. English is a very bald language in comparison, and Ahmad is an English writer. His prose follows English patterns, although his setting is India. He has obviously put great effort into finding out about the period he describes, but to a large extent his main characters stand beyond any time and place, and are dealing with universal human predicaments and emotions, particularly love, loyalty, rejection and the violence.

All in all, *The Storyteller's Tale* proves again what a useful and satisfying form the novella can be. There is no room in it for wasted words. The stories here are simply and thoughtfully told. In short, it is the ideal companion for a journey or a lazy afternoon. ■



SAURABH SINGH